3.4- Agents Of Socialization

Learning objectives

- Define the agents of socialization and explain their role in shaping individual behavior
- Analyze the role of different agents of socialization in the various life stages of an individual

Learning outcomes

- Explain major agencies of socialization process
- Describe the influence of major agencies of socialization in the development of individual development
- Analyze the role of various agencies throughout of persons life

Introduction

Socialization is a process that makes a human being not only biological but also a social being. The process goes on a lifetime. Besides, it is a means of not only sustaining social values and rules but also transporting them from one generation to the next. Therefore socialization is a lifetime journey.

Socialization is not something that happens spontaneously. It occurs through different sources that are known as agents of socialization. These agents are the ones that make the process effective and meaningful

Socialization is otherwise known as social learning. As people follow it, they learn social rules and get skills that help them in society. It is a key concept for the understanding of social life. According to H. T. Majumdar, "Socialization is a process through which social nature of human is formed from natural human nature, and an individual turns into a person."

Different agents are those that play the role of socialization. These agents are the institutions which teach social norms to individuals. They work as a means of shaping people into society members. Every society or community has several agents of socialization. The main ones are: Family, School, Peer Group, State, Society, and Religious Institutions.

Agents of socialization

(a) Family

The family is the first and most significant agency of socialization, where a child learns how to behave. The child's first social world is the family. After that, a baby interacts with its mother, and the love for parents and relatives strongly influences learning. A child gets socialization from two main sources; The first source is children with authority over the child, e.g. parents, teachers, and elders. The second source is children who are equal to the child in status, such as friends and playmates. The child learns discipline and rules from the first group, and from the second group the child learns cooperation and teamwork.

Parents are the first people to socialize the child. They are the closest both physically and emotionally to the child. The mother, among them, has the main role because she spends most of the time with the child. Through daily interactions with parents, siblings, grandparents, uncles, aunts, and cousins, the child learns habits, behaviour, and values. The family teaches love, care, cooperation, respect, and many other qualities.

Family is not always the case of only blood relatives. It can also be the neighbours, close friends, or caregivers who take part in raising the child. In this way, the family is the child's first school, and the mother is the first teacher.

Socialization is a lifelong process, however, childhood is the most significant stage. During the early years, a child's mind is very soft and easily influenced. The love and behaviour of parents and siblings have a great influence on the development of the child's character. A child's growth depends on their family to a great extent. If the family is mean or unhappy, kids might pick up bad habits. On the other hand, if the family is nice and supportive, kids learn to behave well.

Children learn language unconsciously through family interaction. Moreover, it is the family where kids start to realize which behaviours are "appropriate" for their gender. Parents, most of the time without being aware of it, lead their children to the gender roles expected by society and they support them through subtle signals, expectations, and regular practices of childhood.

As an agency of socialization, the family performs the following functions:

- The family is the first group a child is born into. It plays a major role in forming the child's attitudes and behaviour.
- It welcomes the child to the culture, customs, and traditions of society.
- The family provides close, face-to-face interaction which is more effective than any formal teaching.
- It is the family that helps to build the child's essential character and personality.
- The family takes care of most of the child's needs and is the source of their emotional support.
- It controls the child's behaviour in an informal way and acts as a bridge between the child and society.
- The family is the leading institution for socializing the child and getting them ready for life in society.
- It offers the child the chance of meeting and interacting with others as well as building relationships.

The home is where the very first seeds of such qualities as sympathy, cooperation, honesty, truthfulness, justice, and love are sown. At a later time, when these values are taught by schools in a formal way, the child understands and accepts them without any difficulty.

(b) The school:

School is a second main socializing agent. It is through school that a kid gets a formal education which is the major factor for shaping their thoughts and attitudes. Education is the lifeblood of

social development, and a properly structured educational system has the potential to produce well-socialized individuals.. In less developed, non-literate societies, socialization may be completely done within the family. However, in today's sophisticated, modern societies, formal education systems have become an indispensable tool in the preparation of children for mature life.

Besides the basics of reading, writing, and arithmetic, schools perform numerous other functions. They are the places where kids learn to control their conduct, resort to self-discipline, co-operate with friends, obey rules and check their progress by means of organized competition. Apart from academic subjects, schools also gently direct pupils to conform to the society's expectations of life after school, the world of work, and the ethical standards of professional roles - thus providing them with the skills and the right attitude required for adult life in the society.

Home teaching is usually personal and emotionally-based - it is the result of love, care, and intimate relationships, whereas school learning is of a more intellectual and systematic nature. It helps children get acquainted with the standards that are objective, critical thinking, and norms of the public, thus preparing them for the world outside their family which is regulated by rules and is much broader.

Therefore, schools not only develop the intellect but also shape the students' characters, instill in them the civic values and, most importantly, they act as very important links between the period of childhood and that of adulthood.

How Teachers Influence Socialization

We cannot, while discussing the school as an agent of socialization, ignore the role of teachers. After parents, teachers are the most significant people in a child's life. Children have great respect and trust for their teachers, and, in most cases, they imitate their conduct.

Teachers have the utmost influence on students being moulded as per the values and the expectations of the society. A child behaving in an incorrect manner or a socially unacceptable way, people usually blame the child’s upbringing and education when which is the main cause of the behaviour. This indicates the responsibility that the teachers have.

Teachers’ behaviour, personality, and character become the standard for the students to follow. In many different ways, teachers reach, through, their actions, and teaching methods, students.

- ☺ They educate pupils regarding the country's cultural legacy as well as the different social groups.
- ☺ They advocate social values and codes of conduct through combining-organizing activities.
- ☺ The subject matters are taught by them in such a manner that the students can relate the knowledge to the social issues prevailing in the society.
- ☺ They facilitate students in acquiring the fundamental abilities of reading, writing, speaking, and thinking, which, in turn, are the bases for communication in a society.

- ☺ Teachers consider all students to be equal and thus do not discriminate any of them on the bases of caste, religion, or background. In this way, students are familiar with the concepts of equality and fairness.
- ☺ They offer the kids coming from different backgrounds the chance to mingle and get acquainted with one another.
- ☺ They inculcate in the students the respect for cultural traditions and social norms.
- ☺ They clarify community laws, customs, and norms.
- ☺ They assist students in broadening their horizons and give them support when it comes to self-understanding as well as society.

Those points bring us to the conclusion that teachers are powerful agents of socialization. The right kind of teacher will be instrumental in students' successful adjustment to school, which in turn will result in successful social adjustment.

How School Helps in Socialization:

- It brings kids the opportunity to reveal their talents and to build up their characters.
- It provides children with good knowledge, life skills, and valuable life lessons.
- Through group activities, the school facilitates the interaction between students, teachers, and the school community.
- The school is responsible for setting up the system of rules and values that serves as a foundation for the formation of not only discipline but also moral behaviour.
- It equips the young with the right characters for playing different roles in life.
- The qualities of citizenship, independence, confidence, and leadership are imparted through school education.
- Rewards, punishments, and the teachers' conduct have a major role to play in the formation of children's characters
- Schools play an important role in the preservation of cultural values and passing them on to the future generation.
- Besides subjects, children get familiar with time management, teamwork, cooperation, and healthy competition as well.
- Schools aid children in their emotional, social, and intellectual growth and also teach them how to become successful in facing come-changing situations.
- Participating in clubs and groups, students get acquainted with responsibility, social rules, and other essential life skills.
- A child who is able to fit in well at school will be more likely to fit in well in society as well.

(c) Peer Groups:

A peer group can be described as a community of people who share a set of features mostly age, but also interests, social status, gender, or life stage. The friendship groups of children and adolescents generally emerge among pupils, friends from the local area, and teammates, or other children met either at school, in playgrounds, or online spaces.

Friends and Playmates, unlike family members and teachers, also significantly influence the socialization process in terms of interactions, being more equal and often less regulated by the authority. The interaction a child has with his/her peers - people of similar age, interests, and social standing - is an equal one. By them, the child gets to know the behaviour at work and learns popular culture in a subtle way as trends, preferences, entertainment habits, and even forbidden knowledge.

Children together with teenagers are also the most willing to accept the influence of peers over the family in the areas of knowledge and culture. While Families give the first and most important set of values, peer groups bring new angles- slang, trends, attitudes toward authority, fashion, music, even moral reasoning- which can be very different from the ones already known at home. Frequently, the members concerned end up sharing a common outlook by interpreting their experiences through similar lenses and thus strengthening the collective norms. In friendships and play, kids discover the necessity of conforming to group norms, obeying shared rules, and realizing that social life is run under prearranged expectations. According to Haralambos and colleagues, peer group socialization differs from adult-led socialization in three major aspects:

a. Kids help make the rules.

Typically in peer groups, kids do jointly invent or modify the rules thus they are not simply inherited from the adults and followed.

b. They focus on fun now, not later.

Peer groups are more concerned with doing something fun right away and postponing it for later, while adults (like parents or teachers) are mostly about coping with the future and fitting into society in the long run.

c. They may have different values.

Peer groups sometimes hold the belief in principles which are the opposites of the ones taught by the adults, such as staying out late, dressing in a particular way, breaking minor rules. This can cause a conflict zone when the expectations of your friends are at odds with your parents'.

Peer socialization has become a major factor of influence in today's society. The fact is that, young people during their teenage years will more than likely choose to go hanging out or doing other activities with friends than with parents or any other adult figures in their lives. Adolescents and young adults especially in urban or suburban areas where public transportation is available and thus they are granted greater independence, are more likely to go out forming their own streets, clubs, or circles rather than hanging out at each other's homes. Examples of these can be college-life-going students, sports teams, music-fashion tribes, or even more obscure groups like motorcycle clubs or in the worst cases, drug-related communities.

Contrary to that, conflict can emerge when ideals from a peer group contradict the family morals. For instance, a child who has grown up in a disciplined environment might find it awkward to behave in a rebellious or permissive way to gain acceptance from his friends. If these situations occur, children may involuntarily or even deliberately retreat from the family

emotionally or physically - the validation and identity they seek will thus be mostly among the peer circle.

On the other hand, peer groups are undeniably important for social development as they act as a support system, which is needed during the transition period from being a dependent child to an independent adult. To play with the roles, to challenge limits, and to establish loyalty within their groups, adolescents utilize these psychological mechanisms to slowly but surely get ready for maturity and the relationships that come with it.

Why are Peer Groups necessary?

- Cultural Exchange: Among children, the process of learning new behaviours, values, and norms is facilitated through friends. For example, they might quickly learn new slang, adapt to changing style trends, or go through common rituals (like play or tradition).
- Shifting Influence: The influence of a peer over a child's decision-making increases with age. The period of adolescence brings the situation where children tend to seek more advice and guidance from friends than from parents, in matters of looks, relationships, and future careers.
- Behavioural Standards: Peer groups come up with unwritten rules around what is "cool" or "acceptable". Even in small things (like laughter at jokes or coming up with ideas for clothing) ability to influence the behaviour of teens is inherent.
- Peer Pressure and Conformity: The time during which the most significant pressure to be accepted among peers takes place is definitely adolescence. A young person may as a result of this have certain behaviour patterns (e.g., choice of music, games, or even taking up more dangerous activities) in order to get approval. Nevertheless, the point is not only about going against parents' authority- peers also encourage the adoption of good morals (e.g., teamwork, kindness).

(d) Religion

Religion, historically, has been a significant factor in the evolution of society. As a major agent of socialization, religion not only influences the spiritual beliefs but also the ethical behaviour, social identity, and cultural standards of people. By means of faith, rites, symbols, and community involvement, religion educates people on what is morally correct or incorrect, sacred or profane- in most cases tightly linking these values to the inner self.

Religious organizations instruct their followers on how to associate with the material culture of their faith. Besides the ritual objects, religion very often becomes a framework for life's main events- the arrival of a new person to the world, weddings, rites of passage towards adulthood, and funerals becoming not just the familial circle but also the community through these sacred customs.

Anyway, the majority of families perform religious rituals on different occasions throughout the year. Children see their parents going to temples and doing religious activities. They also hear religious teachings or sermons, which can shape their ideas and influence their behaviour later in life. The faith that children grow up with is mostly handed down through their family

and community. Very early, they are already religiously involved through prayers, festivals, and ceremonies like weddings, naming, or funerals. These experiences help build their values and train their minds.

Besides socializing, religion, through its organized nature, is also deeply interwoven in the hierarchical and normative system of society, keeping and passing on the societal expectations of one's gender, authority, morality, and behaviour. Through sermons, scripture, rites of passage, and community roles, religious settings, more often than not, subtly depict and uphold certain norms- these being those connected to masculinity, femininity, hierarchy, and duty. Hence, religion has not only been a source of spiritual guidance but it has also been instrumental to the shaping of one's worldviews, character development, and the perpetuation of a common moral framework that governs both the inner self and the societal structures of a community.

Role of Religion in Socialization:

- Socially, religion is a guide for people towards finding themselves and their moral progression.
- It shapes a person's viewpoints, thoughts, and decision-making processes.
- Along with spirituality, religion teaches people how to live in harmony with society.
- Religion equips a person with a set of beliefs, customs, and values that influence their lifestyle.
- Religion cleanses the mind and promotes positive thinking.
- It motivates children to learn social and cultural norms.
- Religious teachings provide the foundation for the development of social virtues like honesty, kindness, and responsibility.
- The language, attire, manners, and traditions of an individual are to a great extent influenced by their religion.
- Religion facilitates collective identity, thus, allowing people to come together through common faith and practices.

(e) The State:

The condition of the state is one of the major agent of socialization besides the community and family. It stands at the forefront in the power to influence the behaviour and values of its citizens. The state, together with the community, shows "how" people can live responsibly in society. Hence, the state exercises functions of an authoritative agent of socialization.

The state is a big social group to which the children belong also. A state typically consists of four main features:

- Territory - A definite geographical area in which people live.
- Population - People living within that area.
- Government - A ruling authority that makes laws and maintains order.

- Sovereignty - The free and independent authority to govern itself without any external interference.

These characteristics of a state illustrate its significance in the socialization process. The state not only establishes laws for citizens but also sets the expectations of acceptable behavior. Whenever individuals go against these laws, they risk being punished. Hence, the state fashions and regulates human behaviour.

Essentially, the state is progressively becoming a major player in the moulding of individual's lives not only from birth through the entire life cycle. Functions such as healthcare, protection, and early childcare, which were once the exclusive domain of families, have been taken over by formal institutions such as hospitals, public health clinics, social welfare agencies, and insurance systems. Thereby, the state has become the direct and most active agent of socialization for the youngest members of the community, e.g., infants and toddlers.

The state doesn't stop at early care, but it still has a say in the citizens' lives through legal, economic, and social frameworks that set the standards of "proper" behaviour for different stages of life. The whole gamut from education to retirement and civic duty is influenced by national policies, laws, and public institutions. Besides, entities like labour unions and political parties function as the connecting links between people and the state, thus, transmitting citizen needs through the state and at the same time, helping to maintain the norms and values established by the state.

By controlling pivotal life changes- childhood, schooling, work, parenthood, aging- the state quietly alters societal expectations of the roles, responsibilities, and conduct associated with the age group and social status. In this way, it not only governs but also socializes.

How the state helps in Socialization:

- The state frames laws and regulations that serve as guidelines to people's conduct.
- Individuals are obliged to adhere to these regulations, failing which they may face punishment, which in turn educates them about discipline.
- The rules formulated by the state influence the growth of a child's character as well as his/her behaviour.
- State policies are instrumental in the teaching of peace, order, and responsibility.
- Practicing national and international days (such as Independence Day, Republic Day, etc.) fosters patriotism among people.
- The government programmes encourage social values like cooperation, empathy, and unity.
- The state-sponsored culture serves as a platform where children can learn about their past and themselves.
- When the state comprises people from various cultures, it imparts tolerance and respect for diversity to the children.

Through the establishment of regulations and guiding citizens throughout their life stages, the state moulds people's behaviour at different ages and stages. That way, the state becomes a potent agent of socialization.

(f) Mass media

Mass media covers all the methods used for communication in this case the six major communication channels are, radio, television, newspapers, magazines, websites, and other digital portals. These instruments of communication share culture and its components, ideas, values, and norms, through the characters and texts in the world, which are with us every day. In the age of Digital/Modern entertainment, Children are given a broader spectrum of learning opportunities through electronic media, which in effect increases their social and cultural exposure exponentially. Consequently, the process of socialization has ceased to be a mere thing of traditional agents like family and peer groups but media now shares an equally influential, if not a dominant, role in the development of children.

Contemporary media does not simply depict reality rather it is a potent factor in shaping the presented reality, to a large extent, visual and narrative media forms are used in illustrating modern social norms, values, and even myths. The writer points out that even the very construction of the digital platforms has a bearing on one's behaviour and communication.

How Media Shapes Socialization

• Transmitting Culture, Shaping Identity: Mass media is the chief instrument to propagate culture, as it carries the messages concerning the various aspects of the world one of which is beauty along with success, morality, gender roles, consumerism, authority, and social norms etc.

• Constant Exposure: Messages are everywhere e.g. one can see them on billboards, in the news, social media, movies, and ads. These messages exist to assist the fixing and strengthening of societal beliefs (e.g., gender roles, political ideologies, or moral standards) in a brief format.

• Media doesn’t just reflect society- it actively constructs it: Through fiction, pictures, and choice of characters, media comes between the audience and the perception of real life. A kid seeing superhero movies can learn the concepts of justice and courage, while a teen who is exploring the world of Instagram and viewing only the perfect side might come up with the idea of the standard of beauty and thus self-worth.

• Reinforcing- or Challenging- the Status Quo: The main and most significant function of mass media, however, is two-fold: besides assisting the reinforcement of the existing social norms such as the promotion of patriotism, the traditional family structures, or a consumer culture- it is equally capable of challenging and destabilizing the same social norms by demonstrating inequalities, giving volume to the silenced minority groups, or encouraging political dissent.

(g) Workplace as an Socialization Agent

Since adults spend most of their time at work, the workplace is also a place where behaviour is being shaped. Though people have already been socialized by their families and schools, they still have to get used to the rules and culture of the workplace. People at work acquire new skills, make friends and follow the rules and requirements of the company. The working

environment is not the same as at home or in school, so it offers a new kind of socialization experience.

Employees, besides adjusting to the technical demands of their job, also have to adapt to the social aspects of the position. They get to know and deal with co-workers who might be on the same level as them or higher and lower- thus, they modify their conduct depending on status, authority, and the culture of the organization. This practice helps them learn the norms of the structure, chain of command and professional etiquette - which are vital for the smooth running of any institution.

The workplace, in many ways, can be described as a small-world society with a similar social structure to that of the bigger one. Through everyday engagements, workers become conscious of the division of labour, specialization, and class stratification- understanding how different roles contribute to production, prestige, and power. Whatever the setting is- a factory, a corporation, or a service industry - people learn and internalize the norms of productivity, loyalty, ambition, and conformity.

By means of occupational socialization, people not only get to know the skills needed to perform a certain job, but they also find out what personality traits they should have in the given role - be it disciplined, competitive, collaborative, innovative, or obedient. These socialized identities become a part of the individuals and influence their lifestyle choices, political views, consumption patterns, and social circles. Therefore, a job is much more than just a source of income- it is an influential and ongoing socialization agent.

Conclusion

Human personality does not come out of nowhere. Socialization assists people in developing their personalities and in learning how to coexist in society. The process usually starts in the family with the mother, then gradually moves to other family members, and eventually to society as a whole. Social institutions are important players in the development of the people in different aspects. Some of the major agents of socialization include family, peer groups, school, religious institutions, and mass media. The agents transmit to the new members the culture, values, beliefs, and customs. The older ones guide the younger on how to behave in society.

The process of socialization is not limited to a certain stage- it continues throughout one's life. Essentially, socialization is the continuous unfolding whereby humans become fully human as they learn to deal with the societies they live in, contribute to them, and at times even change them.

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Check Your Progress

MCQ

1. Who defined "Socialization is a process through which social nature of human is formed from natural human nature, and an individual turns into a person."?

A) H. T. Majumdar B) Macionis.JJ
C) Peter Worsley D) Lundberg

2. The primary agents of early socialization?
A) Peer group B) Family
C) Media D) Religion

3. Which of the following is considered an formal agent of socialization?
A) School B) Family
C) Peer group D) Mass media

4. Which of the following is considered an informal agent of socialization?
A) School B) Media
C) Workplace D) Government

5. The process by which individuals learn ideas, values and norms through mass communication is called:
A) Anticipatory socialization B) Secondary socialization
C) Media socialization D) Resocialization

Short essay

1. Write a short note on family as an agents of socialization

2. Discuss the role of school in the socialization process

3. Explain the role of peer group in socialization

4. Write a short on the influence of mass media as an agent of socialization

5. Discuss the functions of Religion as an agent in the socialization process?

Essay

1. Define socialization and discuss in detail the major agents of socialization

2. Analyse the role of different agents of socialization in the development of personality and social behaviour

MCQ Answers

1. A) H. T. Majumdar
2. B) Family
3. A) School
4. B) Media
5. C) Media socialization

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